While he was generous to these Muslim embassies, on the contrary, he was fond of hanging the tax-defaulting Indian subjects to trees.

A statement from Bernier gives complete clarity on why the GDP of the Sultānate remained almost constant while GDP/capita growth turned negative. Bernier writes:[†]

> Gold and silver are not in greater plenty here than elsewhere; on the contrary, the inhabitants have less the appearance of a moneyed people than those of many other parts of the globe.

Bernier informs us about the Aurangzeb's period by stating as below:[‡]

> Labourers perish due to bad treatment from Governors. Children of poor are carried away as slaves. Peasantry abandon the country driven by despair. As the land throughout the whole empire is considered the property of the sovereign, there can be no earldoms, marquisates, or duchies. The royal grants consist only of pensions, either in land or money, which the king gives, augments, retrenches or takes away at pleasure.
>
> The artisans who manufactured the luxury goods for the Mughal aristocracy were almost always on starvation wages.

It is crucial to note that the price of goods produced by these artisans was determined by the buyers. When they failed to comply with the price standards as set, they were ought to face imprisonment or death. We are told by Bernier that the weavers who spun the world's finest brocades and garments went about half-naked.

English Ambassador Thomas Roe who had visited the court of Jahangir had observed a similar aspect. He was amazed looking at the diamonds, pearls and rubies displayed in the court of Tīmūrids but at the same time, the impoverished life of common people caught his eyes too along the route from Surat to Delhi.[*]

The 'Introduction' section of this book has details of how Shah Jahan had created the famine of AD 1620–32. Just bear that in mind and note the following.

Shah Jahan had organized a grand feast on Nauroz in AD 1628. All the elites were part of the celebrations. Shah Jahan gifted each member of royalty with abundant gifts and titles as below:

> The imperial consort, Mumtaz Mahal received Rs fifty lakh from the treasury. Jahan Ara, Shah Jahan's daughter from Mumtaz was granted twenty lakh, and her sister Raushan Ara, received a sum of five lakh.

The records tell us that in this period, Shah Jahan had spent Rs 1.6 crore from the public treasury only for granting the rewards and pensions.[†]